

DEMOCRACY AND PARTICIPATION

Direct democracy

Advantages	Disadvantages
- Purest form of democracy. The people's voice is clearly heard - It can avoid delay and deadlock within a political system - The fact that the people are making the decision gives it great legitimacy Referendums have higher turnout than general elections, with 2024 GE having 60% (second lowest since universal suffrage) and 2014 independence (84%) 2016 Brexit (72%)	- It can lead to the 'tyranny of the majority' whereby the winning majority simply ignores the interests of the minority and imposes something detrimental on them - The people may be too easily swayed by short-term, emotional appeals by charismatic individuals - Some issues may be too complex for the ordinary citizen to understand Misinformation during 2016 Brexit referendum, misleading bus claim 'We send the EU 350 million a week, lets fund our NHS instead'

Representative democracy

Advantages	Disadvantages
- Representatives can develop expertise to deal with matters the public does not have the time or knowledge to deal with - Representatives can be held to account for their actions at election time - Representatives have the time to deal with a variety of complex matters, leaving the public free to get on with their own lives - In a large modern country, it is the only practical way to translate public opinion into political action - Elected representatives may have better judgement and be	- Representatives may not act in the best interests of their constituents - It can be difficult to hold a representative to account between elections - Allowing voters to delegate responsibility to representatives can lead to the public disengaging from social issues and other responsibilities - Representative bodies can be unrepresentative and may ignore the concerns and needs of minority groups FPTP leads to votes of unequal value, marginal seats have votes

more rational/ not swayed by emotion - Representatives can protect the interests of minority groups Reform UK MP for Great Yarmouth, Rupert Lowe, voted in favour of the landmark Terminally Ill Adults (End of Life) Bill 2024 after hosting a mini-referendum in his constituency, 75% yes December 5 2023, 22 Conservative MPs supported a Labour amendment aimed at speeding up compensation for victims of the infected blood scandal, rebelling against a 3 line conservative whip to do so	that matter more, e.g Thanet South, Kent which has been won by the winning party at every GE since its creation Economist reported in December 2024 that since 2010, former MPs and ministers have spent a total of 50,000 hours and earned 65 million from doing second jobs YouGov polling, 49% of respondents say they ‘almost never’ trust the British government to place the needs of the nation above the interests of their own party
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PARTICIPATION CRISIS?

	YES	NO
Elections and referendums	- 2024, 60% turnout (Second lowest since universal suffrage) - Turnout among 65+ age group in 2017 was around 25 percentage points higher than among 18-24 year olds	- 2014 Scottish independence referendum and 2016 Brexit referendum had turnouts of 85% and 72% - Significant engagement around critical issues
Party membership	- Mass membership is in decline - Labour membership decreased from 1953 (1 million) to 2026 (333,000) – can no longer be identified as the party of the working class - Tory decrease from 1953 (2.8 million) to 2026 (123,000)	- Surge of party membership for Labour in 2015 when Milliband made it possible to join for just 3 pounds (over 500,000) - Greens membership increased by 80% to 170,000 from September to December 2025 - Reforms membership at 268,000 (early 2026) - Suggest that the public will still use parties as a vehicle for political action if they don't represent the establishment
Group politics	- Decline of the trade union movements	- Rise of new groups around environmental issues

	- 1979 (13.2 million) to 2016 (6.3 million) - Political movements are more fleeting and not seen as a serious form of participation - 'Slacktivism' – January 2025 petition to call immediate general election received over 1 million signatures and was debated in parliament, despite the fact this is very unlikely to happen (more performative than legitimate)	since 60s, people feel that single issue groups are more effective than parties - E.g 2013 the Passionate Collaboration study found that 139 environmental groups they analysed has a total membership of 4.5 million which is nearly 1/10 adults - Social movements are loosely organised and flexible, seeming to emerge quickly in response to issues as they appear - E.g 2003 Iraq protests or 2020 BLM movement - 2024 consistent protests in London and across UK for an immediate ceasefire in Gaza - Age UK e-petition urging gov to reverse winter fuel payments policy received 650,000 signatures
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How democratic is the UK political system

Democratic features	Positives	Negatives
Peaceful transition of power	The uk is remarkably conflict-free	Short-lived disputes have arisen when the results were not clear, in 2010 and in 2017, leading to some claims of a lack of legitimacy
Free elections	Nearly everyone over 18 can vote There is little electoral fraud and there exist strong legal safeguards	Some groups, such as prisoners and effectively the homeless, are denied their right to vote and new voter ID laws are believed to have added to the disenfranchised The HOL is not elected, nor is the head of state (monarch)
Fair elections	There are proportional systems in place in Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland and other devolved and local bodies	The FPTP system for general elections leads to disproportionate results and many wasted votes Governments are often elected on a modest proportion of the popular vote

Widespread participation	There is extensive membership of pressure groups, which are free and active. There is also a growing level of participation in e-democracy	Since 2001, voter turnout in general elections has been, on average, lower than in previous elections, while party membership, especially among the young, has generally been in decline. Despite some increases in party membership after 2015, it is still below levels experienced in the 1950s
Freedom of expression	The press and broadcast media are free of government interference. Broadcast media maintain political neutrality. There is free access to the internet	Much ownership of the press is in the hands of a few large, powerful companies such as News international, the owners of which tend to have their own political preferences Some information available on the internet is false and detrimental There is some dependent over how independent the BBC is and attempts by politicians to influence its reporting
Freedom of association	There are no restrictions on legal organisations People may organise and instigate public protests	The government has the power to ban some groups based on the potentially unfair perception of their activities Public meetings and demonstrations can be restricted on the grounds of 'public order'
Protection of rights and liberties	The country is signed up to the ECHR The HOL advocates for rights	Parliament is sovereign, which means rights are at the mercy of a government with a strong majority in the commons The ECHR is not binding on the UK parliament
The rule of law	Upheld strictly by the judiciary The right to judicial review underpins this The judiciary is independent and non-political	The monarch is exempt from legal restrictions There is statistical evidence to suggest social and economic standing impact severity of sentencing
A constitution	Parliament and the courts ensure the government acts within the law The HRA acts as a restraint on the actions of the gov, and constitutional checks exist to limit the power of gov	There is no codified UK constitution so the limits on government power are vague Parliamentary sovereignty means the government's power could be increased without a constitutional safeguard The prerogative powers of the PM are extensive and arbitrary

Potential democratic reforms for the UK:

Potential reform	Advantages	Disadvantages
Replace the HOL with an elected chamber	It would remove an unelected, unaccountable body from the UK's democratic process	What replaced it might cause greater rivalry with the commons, leading to gridlock in the legislative process The expertise in the lords could be replaced by career politicians
Replace FPTP with more proportional system	Remove the negative features of FPTP such as safe seats, minority constituencies, unfair representation and minority governments	Proportional systems make coalitions more likely and harder to hold to account. The systems are more complex and risk losing the close MP constituency link
Codify the UK constitution	Would clarify the processes of the UK political system and provide a higher law that would be entrenched 59% in YouGov poll want a written constitution	A codified constitution might prove too rigid and there are questions about who would write it and how it would be implemented It would raise questions over the location of sovereignty Would give more power to unelected judges
Create a devolved English Parliament to equalise devolution	Would solve the West Lothian question and create a more equal level of representation across the UK	England is too large a single entity to work within a devolved system, but regional devolution has been rejected by voters
Introduce full state party funding	Would allow politicians to focus on their main job rather than fundraising Would potentially remove the need to acquire money from powerful groups and vested interests that donate for their own ends, not national interest	The process of fundraising helps to keep politicians and parties connected to voters Questions would be raised over how funding would be allocated and whether taxpayer money should be given to parties that some may disagree with
Introduce compulsory voting	Would increase turnout in all elections, helping improve the legitimacy of elected officials In Australia turnout increased from 70% to 90%	Forcing people to vote may not improve public engagement in politics The right to vote also includes the right not to vote
Replace the monarch with an elected head of	Would remove an unelected figurehead and replace them with an elected and accountable figure	The monarchy is popular, and, being neutral, can act as a unifying figure in a way an elected politician cannot 48% of population in favour of replacement

state (President)		
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Digital democracy:

Any petition gaining 10,000 signatures would receive a government response and any receiving 100,000 would be considered for parliamentary debate

Year	Subject	Signatures	Outcome
2011	Calling for the release of documents relating to the Hillsborough football disaster of 1989	139,000	Following a parliamentary debate, the papers were released, and a new inquest was launched
2016	Should there be a second EU referendum?	3.8 million	A parliamentary debate was held on the issue but no second referendum was allowed
2019	'Don't put our NHS up for negotiation'	169,000	The government responded by saying: 'the NHS is not and never will be for sale to the private sector'
2020	End child food poverty – no child should be going hungry	1 million	Debated in parliament but the aim of expanding lunch provisions during the school holidays failed However, in response, the government announced over 400million in funding for the next 12 months to support low income families with the cost of food and bills

Should the UK adopt compulsory voting?:

YES	NO
- May force voters, especially the young, to make themselves more informed about political issues	- Civil liberties violation. The right to vote also includes the right not to vote

- By increasing turnout, it would give greater democratic legitimacy to the party or individuals who win an election - By ensuring that more sections of society are involved, decision-makers would have to ensure that policies address the concerns of all parts of society, not just those who typically vote in larger numbers - Voting is a civic duty so citizens should be obliged to carry out that duty - Ensures that marginalised and disadvantaged groups are more likely to participate - In 2005 General Election, Labour won a commons majority with the support of only 22% of the electorate - UK general elections consistently show lower turnout among young people, renters and those in lower income groups	- Many voters are not well informed and yet they would be voting, so there would be low quality participation - Would involve large amounts of public expenditure to administer and enforce the system - Would favour large parties against small parties. This because less-informed citizens would vote and they may have heard only of better-known parties and can assured - High turnout isn't inherently indicative of a healthy democracy - The Hansard Society Audit of political Engagement repeatedly shows that many non-voters report distrust, not apathy, as their reason for abstaining - Compulsory voting has been criticised for increasing protest or extremist voting rather than informed participation
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Should prisoners be able to vote?:

YES	NO
- Hirst V UK (2005): The ECHR ruled that the UK's blanket ban on prisoner voting breached the right to free elections, prisoner voting would thus bring the UK into line w human rights norms - If prisoners are able to continue their lives as citizens then they should not be excluded from political participation - Civil liberties for all are key to a healthy democracy - Some prisoners with equal sentences for the same crime can vote whilst others cannot based off of when they are released - Prison disproportionately affects ethnic minorities – so we should enfranchise to adapt to ongoing racial	- Freedom from executive coercion is essential if people are to produce/ consume policy alternatives - Prisoners shouldn't be on par with other citizens when it comes to democratic rights - Appropriate punishment for committing crime, no longer allowed civil liberties - Allowing prisoners to vote would not achieve the harder and more pressing aim of having fewer people imprisoned - If you violate the social contract, then your right to vote and participate is taken away - Cross-party opposition in Parliament to prisoner voting has remained strong since the 1970s

discrimination - Parliamentary committee stage – draft voting eligibility (prisoners) bill or franchise prisoners if serving a sentence of less than 4 years - Prisoner reintegration made more difficult with right to vote taken away – reoffending rate 25% - The UK is in a minority in Europe, with many countries allowing either full or partial prisoner voting - Prison populations disproportionately include people from working class and ethnic minority backgrounds, intensifying political exclusion	- Former PM David Cameron described Prisoner voting as making him feel ‘physically ill’ - Empirical studies show that voter turnout among eligible prisoners remains extremely low, largely due to administrative barriers - Public opinion surveys consistently show limited public support for extending voter rights to prisoners
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Should 16-17 year olds be able to vote?:

Recent proposals by the Labour government to reduce voting age to 16 have resurfaced debates on extending the franchise

YES	NO
- With the spread of citizen education, young people are now better informed about politics than ever before - Voting turnout among the 18-24 year old age group is very low. This may encourage more people to vote and become engaged with politics - The internet and social media now enable young people to be better informed about politics - If one is old enough to serve in the army and pay tax, one should be old enough to vote - The radicalism of younger people could act as a balance to the conservatism of some older voters - Citizenship education has been compulsory in secondary schools since 2002, weakening arguments that young voters lack political knowledge - Turnout among 16-17 year olds was estimated at around	- 16 and 17 year olds are too young to be able to make informed decisions and are now required to be in some form of education until 18 - Many issues are apparently too complex for younger people to understand - Not all people in this age group pay tax so they are seen to have a lower stake in society - Younger people can be excessively radical as they have not had enough life experience to consider issues carefully - Essentially gives parents another vote - Younger voters remain the least likely age group to vote in the UK wide general elections, even after major political events such as Brexit – risks lowering overall turnout

75% in the 2014 Scottish independence referendum compared with approx 54% among 18-24 year olds	
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PRESSURE GROUPS

Causal groups: Seek to promote a specific cause

E.g Greenpeace, Liberty, PETA

Sectional groups: represent a particular section of society

Try to change parliament policy and require formal membership

E.g BMA (British medical association), Age UK

Insider groups: Close links to government, seek to become involved in the early stages of law making, imply professional lobbyists

May be directly involved via government special committees e.g NFU (The national farmer's union) and the IOD (institute of directors)

Outsider groups: more radical groups, promotional, public campaigning and protests

E.g Just Stop Oil

Case study: ASH (Action on smoking and health)

- Founded in 1967 by academics and interested parties
- Objectives include the spreading of knowledge about the harmful effects of tobacco use and pressing governments to adopt policies and laws to reduce tobacco use

Methods

- Conducts research and shares existing research into the effects of tobacco with the government and the public
- Sponsored research into the effects of passive smoking and e-cigarettes
- Largely an insider group, concentrating on lobbying law-makers and governments
- It mainly uses scientific data to underpin its case

Successes

- Restrictions on advertising tobacco products and tobacco sponsorship
- Health warnings on cigarette packs
- Persuading government to increase tax on tobacco to deter consumers
- Restricting point-of-sale advertising and promotion
- Campaigning for the law banning smoking in public spaces
- Persuading government to develop a law banning smoking in cars carrying children
- Persuading government to consider adding messages to quit smoking inside packets of cigarettes

Failures

- As of yet, has not succeeded in changing government policy in the area of vaping, struggling with colourful adverts for vapes that appeal to children

Case study: The RMT union (national union of rail, maritime and transport workers)

- Founded in 1990 through the merger of two other union groups
- Objectives include the promotion of better pay and conditions for its members, including shorter hours and safer working environments

Methods

- Negotiates contracts with major transport companies (e.g TFL) on behalf of its members
- Lobbies governments for better legislative protections and workers' safety
- Organises and conducts strikes to pressure employers to meet its demands, which can be effective due to the dominance of the RMT in key sectors, such as tube drivers in London
- Runs its own credit union to help support its members financially
- Mostly affiliated with the Labour Party, has in the past put up candidates for election and endorsed other parties that it feels better represents its members' interests

Successes

- 2016 the RMT secured 500 pound consolidation payment to all operational staff following the introduction of the Night Tube service
- Has helped members bring legal cases following injury and wrongful termination, including a 55,000 pound payment to a member who lost the tip of an index finger in an industrial accident
- Securing bonus payments for workers during the 2012 olympics
- Repeal of the minimum Service Levels 2024
- Improving safety standards on offshore oil platforms as well as on trains and ferries

Failures

- Union condemned the implementation of Network Rail's modernising maintenance program which was forced through without union agreement and led to a significant cut in jobs and increased safety risks
- Ticket office closures 2015-2016 – series of 48 hour strikes and legal challenges but failed to stop TFL from closing 289 ticket offices by June 2016

Pressure group effects:

- Insider groups can have very good leverage such as the NFU and British Bankers Association and Stonewall. If the group is trusted by gov they have more influence
- Pressure groups can mount legal challenges – Gov policy on Rwanda criticised by Amnesty International. Upon the passing of the Safety of Rwanda Bill, Amnesty stated it would 'leave a stain on this country's moral reputation'
- Sisters Uncut significantly impact the MET police by challenging their handling of the Sarah Everard case, forcing legal, cultural and leadership changes
- River action – pressuring the government and agricultural supply chains to address pollution, specifically citing the crisis in the River Wye
- The Environment Agency works with government to shape policies for the UK's 2050 Net Zero target, including developing guidance for carbon capture and storage (CCS) and hydrogen production

Think tank: Chatham House

Funding

- Charity that does not take any government funding
- Funded by diverse mix of membership fees, corporate partners (shell, Chevron, Apple, BP) and foundations (Carnegie Corp etc)

Client list

- Chatham House publicly lists its major donors and corporate members which constitute its primary funding source rather than a confidential 'client list'

Aims

- Try to champion human rights and strive for a more just world and influence the international stage

Methods

- Chatham House Rule, a principle for confidential discussions where participants can use information but not reveal the speaker's identity or affiliation, encouraging open dialogue on sensitive topics by providing anonymity

Successes

- Venezuela Roadmap: developed a plan to restart democracy negotiations, influencing international business and investors
- Convened experts on climate risk and co-founded the Public AI Network to guide technology policy for the common good
- Contributed research on NATO's role in climate security challenges

Failures

- Concerns about outdated image
- Influenced by special interests, perceived elitism, potential alignment with western foreign policy agenda
- Accusations that the 'Chatham House rule' has not been properly kept

Think tank influence:

- IEA (Institute of Economic Affairs) is a free-market think tank with close links to the Conservative party. Kwarteng's failed mini budget of 2020 was heavily in line with the ideas of the IEA

- The Centre for Policy Studies and the Adam Smith Institute were central to Thatcherism (1979-1990)
- 2020 Tory government were scrutinised by the National Institute of Economic and Social Research about the gov's budget and raised questions over the viability of its growth targets
- Senior officials in Demos (politically neutral think tank that is used by lots of sitting governments) were given roles in New Labour

Lobbies: PLMR (political lobbying and media relations limited)

Funding: Funded by charity clients and donates 5% of its profits to Charity

Clients :DHL, Cancer Research UK, The Food Foundation (Marcus Rashford)

Aims :To influence public opinion and help shape political policy

Methods

- Combining deep political expertise (e.g Anne Milton former Tory MP who had ministerial roles in health) with public relations, media, and digital skills to influence policy and public opinion for clients, focusing on stakeholder engagement

Success

- Boost Bingo Campaign: Won the Public Affairs Campaign Category at the 2021 PR week awards for the Bingo Association
- Food foundation: supported the creation of a map to show locations providing free school meals to children during the school holidays

Lobbying scandals:

- Investigations by The Times revealed that major tobacco firms have been secretly funding 'independent' activist groups and lobbying campaigns to promote e-cigarettes and block regulations on youth vaping in the UK
- The Guardian reported that Entain, the owner of Ladbrokes, funded a lobbying operation aimed at weakening proposed government gambling reforms, despite publicly supporting them

Corporations: Starbucks

Funding

- The Starbucks Foundation, along with global Licensee partners, have provided over \$3million to World Central Kitchen to provide more than 1 million meals to families in Gaza

Successes

- NHS Charities Together (UK): Supports NHS staff and communities, donating food, drink and funds for well-being
- Harry Kane Foundation/ Bounce Forward (UK): Supports youth mental health initiatives
- Too Good To Go – partnered with Europe to prevent excessive food waste and surplus

Failures

- Starbucks continues to open new stores in the UAE as part of broader regional expansion, despite the UAE funding the militias groups in the Sudan Civil War
- Boycott related losses: Following the start of the conflict in Gaza in October 2023, Starbucks faced significant boycotts over perceived support for Israel, leading to reported \$11billion drop in market value between November and December 2023

Do pressure groups enhance or threaten democracy?

Enhance democracy	Threaten democracy
- Help to disperse power and influence more widely - Educate the public about important political issues - Give people more opportunities to participate in politics without having to sacrifice too much time and attention - Promote and protect the interests and rights of minority groups - Help to call government to account by publicising the effects of policy	- Some pressure groups are considered elitist and tend to concentrate power in too few hands - Influential pressure groups may distort information in their own interests - Pressure groups that are internally undemocratic may not accurately represent the views of their members and supporters - Finance is a key factor in political influence, so groups that are wealthy may wield a disproportionate amount of influence - The use of civil disobedience, particularly illegal actions, can undermine the freedoms and rights of other citizens

Factors influencing the success of pressure groups

Factors	Success	Failure
Size of membership	The more supporters a group has, the more pressure It can place on decision-makers Politicians do not like to fly in the face of public opinion because they regularly face the need of re-election	Smaller groups can be overlooked or ‘drowned out’ by the campaigns of larger groups. They find it harder to raise funds and achieve their goals with fewer participants
Finance	Wealthy groups can afford expensive campaigns, employ lobbyists, sponsor political parties and purchase favourable publicity	Groups with less funding struggle to organise effective campaigns, hire lobbyists and fund production of leaflets, websites and other research, and therefore struggle to make their voices heard
The strategic position of a particular sectional group	A group that Is seen as more important to the economy or a key service cam put greater pressure on the government Companies and industrial groups have a great deal of leverage because they are vital to the economy, as do NHS workers	Groups that are not seen as important can easily be ignored, especially if they are competing against a strategically important group: the Occupy movement failed in part because it was up against the strategically important finance sector
Public mood	The combination of public sentiment and strong campaigning can be successful in bringing an issue to the attention of decision-makers as politicians are more likely to support a popular cause	Public mood can turn politicians against certain groups, either for the issue they champion, such as prisoner or terrorist rights, or because the methods they use alienate public opinion
Attitude of the government	Groups are far more likely to achieve success if the government of the day is sympathetic to their cause and position	If the government of the day is determined to follow a particular course of action that a group opposes, it is very unlikely that they will be able to change the government’s decision, notably seen in the failure of the 2003 Stop the War coalition

RIGHTS

Common law rights: The traditional status of rights in the UK has been that every citizen was assumed to have rights unless they were prohibited by law. 'Negative rights'. Rights were also sometimes specifically stated as a result of a court case when these rights were in dispute, in doing so a judge was declaring Common Law. This creates judicial precedent.

HRA 1998: The HRA brought into effect the ECHR, which was established by the Council of Europe in 1950. The UK helped to draft the Convention but did not accept it as binding on its government until 1998.

- Traditionally, the UK relied on a series of negative rights, meaning they existed in an absence of law and were very difficult to enforce, with people's protections very limited.
- With the introduction of the HRA, these negative rights were supplanted by positive rights that had to be legally protected and respected.
- HRA is binding on all public bodies other than the UK parliament (politically binding but not legally binding) and enforced by all courts in the UK

Freedom of Information Act 2000: Historically, citizens had no right to see information held by public bodies. Labour gov of 1997 thus passed this Act.

- Has proved an invaluable tool for social and political campaigners, for MPs and for the media, allowing them to discover information that was never available in the past. Helped to improve services such as the health service, the police, the civil service and educational establishments by shedding light on their activities.
- It was through the Freedom of Information Act that the Daily Telegraph was able to publicise the MPs expenses scandal of 2009

The Equality Act 2010: the two parliamentary statutes prior to the Equality Act that established formal equality in the UK (The Race Relations Act 1965 and The Equal Pay act 1970) missed out many important groups in society who have suffered discrimination)

- The Act requires that all legislation and decision-making made by government at any level must take into account formal equality of different sections of society.

Civil liberties – protect citizens gains they government and state

Civil rights – atomising we are all born with

Individual rights – right to freedom of expression, many codified in HRA and ECHR

Collective rights – rights of interest groups or communities e.g right to religious groups or native communities

Ashers Baking Company V Lee 2018

- Bakery refused to make a cake that said ‘Support Gay Marriage’
- SC ruled in favour of bakery, holding that the refusal was based on the opposition to the message rather than the personal characteristics of the customer

R v Director of Public Prosecutions 2021

- Anti arms trade protestors who obstructed a highway near the site of an arms fair
- SC ruled in their favour based off of freedom of expression and peaceful assembly
- Their actions were in line with their right to protest

Independent Workers Union of GB v Deliveroo 2021

- Deliveroo drivers wanted union power, but the IWGB said because they were single hours contract they weren’t entitled to it
- SC ruled in favour of Deliveroo

R v Secretary of State for Housing 2020

- Gov wanted to put limits on who could live in public spaces e.g said that homeless people could not live in public spaces, homeless response was that it infringed on their individual lives
- Gov countered with the collective interest of maintaining public spaces and preventing anti-social behaviour
- Court ruled against the claimants arguing that the collective rights of the community were above the individual rights of the homeless

How effectively does the UK's democracy protect human rights and civil liberties

It does	It doesn't
Judicial review allows citizens to challenge decisions made by public bodies, including the government, which they believe may	Judicial review – the ECHR and HRA are coming under attack from the right

be unlawful: - The UK has one of the best records amongst the 47 ECHR members of compliance with decisions of the ECHR - Parliament has previously changed decisions based on the rulings of the European Courts e.g Parliament formation of the Modern Slavery Act 2015, Case brought which criticised UK for not having robust laws against forced labour and domestic servitude - Mental Capacity Act 2005 which passed following a ruling in the ECHR which found that the UK lacked adequate legal protection for the liberty of people with mental capacity issues who were detained	- January 2026 Reform UK's Farage and Conservatives Badenoch want to leave the ECHR due to opinions that it destroys parliamentary sovereignty - Tories 2019 electoral pledges to update Human rights with British Bill of Rights - 30th July 2020 – Tory gov established an independent panel to see if there was a requirement to reform the judicial review process - HRA is an act that can be repealed with simple majority - Judicial review is not binding on parliament
During culture for the respect of civil liberties within parliament and public bodies: - Parliament has established a joint committee on Human Rights – made up of both HOL peers and HOC MPs to scrutinise government bills and make sure they are aligned with HRA – e.g March 2020 the committee opened an investigation to assess if the government had dealt with Covid effectively - Public organisations such as Mersey Care trust NHS work to make sure that parliament respects public rights - Equality and Human rights commission investigated into pay discrimination towards women at the BBC	Is this a real commitment to rights or just 'lip service' - Labour government Anti Terrorism, Crime and Security Act 2001 – introduced indefinite detention for terror suspects which was ruled incompatible in the Belmarsh case and they renewed it with the Prevention of Terrorism Act 2005 - Conservatives Coronavirus Act 2020 has been subject to abuse from human rights organisations such as Liberty and the British Institute of Human Rights, especially when it comes to the rights of older adults and children
Now in society there is a far greater awareness of ones civil liberties and thus a protection of civil rights as there is greater public support: - The Howard League and Prison Reform Trust has run a long term campaign about human rights in prisons and has achieved legislative success e.g Books for Prisoners 2024 – overturned restrictions on books and allowed	Whilst there is a support for laws dealing with human rights in the UK, there is growing criticism for how they work: - Tories want to re-establish the HRA and make it a British Bill of Human Rights after issues with the European court who have been accused of not understanding the UK's human rights traditions - Human rights inflations e.g the inflation of the right to

84,000 inmates access to reading materials - Liberty has been vocal about the HRA weaknesses and a lack of care for discrimination policies e.g The campaign of Zero Discrimination Day in March 2025 – focused on combatting discrimination in the workplace and healthcare	family life has severely limited the state in deporting illegal immigrants in recent years, around 61,000 appeals were successful in their first tier tribunal
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Strengths and weaknesses of rights in the UK

Strengths	Weaknesses
- There is a strong common law tradition - The UK is subject to the ECHR - The judiciary has a reputation for being independent and upholding the rule of law, even against the expressed wishes of government and parliament - The principle of equal rights is clearly established	- Common law can be vague and disputed. It can also be set aside by parliamentary statutes - Parliament remains sovereign and so can ignore the ECHR or even repeal the HRA - There is increasing political pressure on government to suspend laws or ignore rulings relating to a variety of political issues, such as terrorist behaviour or the rights of asylum seekers - That equality means can be subject to interpretation and see some groups coming into conflict over the enforcement of their rights, for example religious groups and LGBTQ+ groups

Liberty: National Council for Civil Liberties (NCCL)

Non-profit, operates like a think tank and membership association, causal pressure group

- Founded in 1934 with the aim of challenging government measures to restrict freedoms in the UK and combat the rising threat of fascism
- Its objectives are to fight to protect and uphold civil rights and liberties across the UK and to develop a wider ‘rights culture’ across society

Methods

- Carries out research and investigations into rights abuses and restrictions and seeks to publicise these through media campaigns
- Uses both mainstream traditional media and social media to spread awareness and develop support
- Supports and brings legal challenges against rights abuses, challenging what it regards as unfair or unjust laws that restrict civil liberties - E.g recent legal challenge to lockdown restrictions
- Providing legal advice and support to cases of discrimination
- Works with government and parliament to advise on legislation and ensure they comply with the HRA
- Regularly organises petitions, protests and public demonstrations to raise awareness of issues

Successes

- July 2023 Liberty part of group of 290 organisations that signed a Joint Civil Society Statement on the Illegal Immigration Act 2023, explaining why it believed the Act was in violation of key human rights
- June 2023 launched a legal challenge to the home secretary's use of secondary legislation to introduce new powers to restrict protocols
- 2022 Liberty provided a briefing on the Bill of Rights to advise MPs during the Second Reading Stage in the HOC. 2023, the government announced it wasn't going to move forward with it
- 2020 liberty brought case under HRA to successfully pressurise Bournemouth, Christchurch and Poole (BCP) Council into removing parts of the Public spaces Protection Order that had been used to criminalise rough sleepers and beggars

Failures

- Liberty has failed in its campaign to achieve a ban on the use of facial recognition in the UK< which is still used by many security organisations
- Despite organising online petitions and campaigns against lockdown restrictions, the government continued to impose such restrictions in the name of public health
- October 2019 the Court of Appeal rejected an application by Liberty to bring a legal case that would have prevented a no-deal Brexit from the European Union

Amnesty international

- Founded in London in 1961 by barrister Peter Benenson, who claimed he was inspired by an account of two Portuguese students who had been sentenced to seven years in prison for drinking a toast to liberty
- Operates as a global campaign group or an international NGO
- Protests wherever it believes justice, freedom, truth, and liberty have been denied
- In addition to exposing and ending abuses, it aims to educate society and mobilise the public to create a safer society

Methods

- Main focus has been on raising public awareness of human rights abuses and other infringements of civil liberties, while also mobilising public support to put pressure on government to act and support reform
- Traditionally done through a letter-writing campaign – local branches and smaller groups tasked with writing to an ‘at-risk individual’ to show support as well as writing letters to the government concerned or to other governments in the hope that they will pressurise the offending government into taking action
- Today, uses email and twitter such as the hashtags #FreeNazanin, which it used to pressurise the British and Iranian governments into releasing the British-Iranian author Nazanin Zaghari-Ratcliffe
- Gives advice and produces template letters and emails for people to fill in themselves
- Organises petitions, public demonstrations and vigils to raise awareness
- Carries out extensive research and publishes reports to highlight issues and educate the public

Successes

- March 2020, Nazanin Zaghari-Ratcliffe was freed from Iranian imprisonment and returned to the UK
- 2020 Amnesty may have contributed to changes to COVID 19 lockdown laws by having supporters petition the government to ensure emergency laws protected the most vulnerable – poverty, disabled, abusive partners
- 2018 declared NI near total ban on abortion services incompatible with HRA. Facilitated the ruling, gathered evidence, pressured the government

Failures

- Amnesty continued to produce reports and raise public concern over Illegal Immigration Bill, but it passed nonetheless
- UK Public Order Act 2022 was passed despite Amnesty's opposition to it
- Despite Amnesty arranging 38,000 members in online action, unable to prevent the Chinese government from detaining muslim groups living in Chinese territory

POLITICAL PARTIES

How effectively do political parties support democracy in the UK

	Yes	No
Policy formulation	Political parties are one of the key means through which societies set collective goals and formulate public policy In the process of seeking power, parties develop programmes for government in manifestos which try publish prior to an election so the public can better decide who to vote for E.g 2024 election Green Party manifesto highlighted increasing green energy and Labour highlighted giving more funds to the NHS	Effectiveness of parties in formulating policy has been questioned – parties have moved away from their original ideological goals for society E.g Labour 2024 manifesto highlighted doing better than the Tories and ending 14 years of chaotic rule
Recruitment of leaders	Parties control the process to choose a candidate to stand for election Parties act as a training ground for future party leaders, allowing politicians to gain experience E.g Stamer shadow Secretary of State for Exiting the European Union from 2016-2020 prior to leadership	Parties will choose leaders who are most popular rather than competent Selection of party leadership has switched from elected MPs to the party membership - membership of the party is only about 2% of the population and is not democratically accountable yet has disproportionate power E.g Election of JC who was ideologically out of touch with large proportion of his party and BOJO who was closed in 2019 by a small group of members
Organisation	Operation of gov relies on party in many ways: parties	Minimal party unity and chaotic internal conflict

of Gov	help to form gov and give it a degree of stability and coherence They organise the legislative program and opposition parties provide a source of opposition and scrutiny to keep gov in check	E.g 2025 when many backbench MPs disagreed with Stamer about cutting winter fuel allowances which resulted in huge rebellion and 52 Labour MPs didn't participate in the vote Instability can occur if a party has a small majority such as May post-2017 election, alliance with DUP
Participation and mobilisation	Political parties provide opportunities for citizens to join a group of like-minded people and therefore help to shape party policy Help to educate and to mobilise the electorate through a range of activities: public meetings, canvassing, party broadcasts	Voter party alignment has declined – in 2015 only 9% of voters claim to have very strong attachment to the party Previously in 1965 it was 44% Turnout in GE has decreased since 1997 Membership of Labour and conservatives has fallen showing a distancing of party alignment Despite new high membership for Green and Reform, 2024 had second lowest turnout since universal suffrage (60%)
Representation	Seen as primary function of liberal democracy Winning party can claim a popular mandate to govern as they were voted in based off their manifesto E.g Labour associated with representing the working class and Tories representing private businesses Allowed TB to implement wide-scale constitutional change post 1997	Labour are questionably representing the working class PIP scandal in April 2025 (100 MP rebellion threat so u-turned) and cut to WFA (52 MPs didn't vote) No longer represent the socialist values that the party was built on Labour seemingly attacking weakest members of society which does not represent their mass of working-class more socialist voters

Should UK parties be state funded?

YES	NO
- State funding would reduce parties' perceived dependence on vested interest – state funding would allow parties to be more responsive to the views of party members and voters – increase public trust as they can't be swayed by private	- Taxpayers may object to funding what can be considered 'private' organisations or parties with views that contradict their own - Parties might lose some of their independence and be seen

investors - State funding could be allocated based on an agreed measure of parties popularity and democratic engagement – would create level playing field for the parties and remove unfair advantages that some parties have due to wealthy donors e.g 2019 Election Tories got 12 million in party donations and Labour only got 4 million - Current regulation of party funding is poor – since passed PPARA in 2000, allegations that donations secure peerages have continued e.g 1997 ecclestone scandal - Phillips report in 2006 highlighted how each party could be given around 25 million per year of taxpayers money to carry out their functions	as organs of the state - A reliable income stream from the state would weaken party links to the electorate and larger society – at the moment, parties need to reach out to society and recruit members and gain public trust. If given state allowance, they wouldn't need to do this E.g under JC the party generated a very healthy membership income stream. Tory party also looked to reach out to society by expanding its base and increasing membership from 124,000 (2018) to 160,000 (2019) - Currently Green Party have huge membership of 170,000 which has increased by 80% since September when ZP came to leadership. Shows how leaders need to make an effort to create a mass movement and rally support - Could create a bias in favour of existing parties if the level of state funding reflects past party performance – would solidify UK as two party system
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Minor parties

SNP	- centre left party who prioritise calls for Scottish independence - Founded in 1934 and broke into gov in 2007 - Alex Salmond led campaign up to 2014 independence referendum - Key policies: Scottish independence, progressive taxation, stronger welfare state, investment to public services, rejoining EU, environmental stability - Influence: amplified calls for constitutional reform, shape debates on Brexit and fiscal policy (e.g consistently oppose UK departure from EU and wants Scotland to have different status) - Irrelevance: Parliament rejected calls for a second referendum, arrest of former chief of executive Peter Murrell 2023
DUP	- Pro union and anti Republican Party in NI, conservative socially and oppose same sex marriage and abortion

	- Founded by Ian Paisley - Key policy: leading voice against NI protocol, say that post-Brexit customs in NI undermine UK constitution - Influence: 2017 general election entered a confidence and supply agreement with Theresa May due to her losing overall majority in 2017 election. In exchange given 1 billion for NI - Irrelevance: since 2019 Tories got a majority so no need to appease them. In 2022 DUP lost position as NI largest party to Sinn Féin
Plaid Cymru	- Want to safeguard Welsh culture and language, soft form nationalism - Current leader = Iwan Iorweth - Key policies: Welsh independence, environmental stability and social equality - Influence: advocated for referendums in 1997 and 2011 that later expanded devolved powers to the Senedd. Push for Welsh language protection and influenced the creation of S4C (Welsh language broadcaster) to increase cultural symbols. Formal cooperation agreement with Welsh Labour - Irrelevance: return only 3-4 MPs in HOC, support is concentrated in Welsh speaking areas, don't appeal to urban groups. 2023 = report of internal misconduct as leaders failed to address bullying and harassment
Green	- Originally only focused on climate policy but now represent broad left-leaning party - Current leader is Zack Polanski as of September 2025 - Key policies: PR, progressive taxation, net zero by 2050, protect nature and animal life, greener and fairer homes, rent control, legalisation of drugs - Influence: Greens opposed 2 child benefit cap and Rachel Reeves removed in Nov 2025. ZP = bringing greater scrutiny to Labour about Gaza and putting more pressure on gov to act (170,000 members as of Dec 2025), seen as replacement of Labour in left-wing policies - Irrelevance: 2024 only have 4 seats in parliament and only won 6.4% of the vote, ambitions seen as unrealistic and extreme, only have access to properly scrutinise gov on 3 opposition days, ZP not in parliament
Reform UK	- Eurosceptics, champion immigration reform, successor of previous parties such as UKIP and Brexit Party - Leader is Nigel Farage who is an MP for Clacton as of 2024 - Key policies: pledge to freeze all non essential immigration, oppose current UK net zero 2050 climate target, lower taxes and stop wasteful government spending, changing FPTP, want to hire 40,000 new

	police and abolish Lords - Influence: Labour w harsher immigration policies – Shabana Mahmood as of Nov 2025 has stated that migrants will be split up from families upon arrival (labour co-opt reform ideas) Farage influenced 2016 Brexit referendum, 2024 Lee Anderson, suella braverman defected from Tories to Reform - Irrelevance: despite 14% of the vote share, FPTP holds them back, public prestige ruined in 2023 when Welsh leader Mark Reckless was implicated in scandal involving Russian Influence
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Are minor parties important?

Yes	No
- Greens membership increased by 80% to 170,000 from September to December - Reform has double the amount of members as the conservatives - 2016 UKIP influence Cameron to enact referendum of leaving EU - Reform have influenced Labour's immigration laws e.g Nov 2025 Shabana Mahmood new policies - Most important and effective when small gov e.g May and DUP confidence and supply agreement in 2017 - Influence election despite not winning many seats – 2024 election Reform were huge competition to tories despite winning only 5 seats and 14% of vote. Contributed to Labour landslide victory as no cohesive opposition	- Small amount of MPs in parliament so not a huge influence on policy (reform only have 5 and greens only have 4) so despite external influence, influence in HOC small - Never won an election alone - FPTP makes it difficult to win seats as it only rewards geographically concentrated parties - Gov debates official opposition which is the Tories. - Only 17 opposition days for official opposition and 3 days shared amongst all other parties, so not a lot of time for open scrutiny apart from PMQs

Is the UK a two-party system?

Yes	No
- In terms of General Elections, the UK remains a two party system. All gov formed 1945 have been Tory or Labour, these two parties continue to dominate in terms of	- Two party system no longer due to breakdown of party identification – Labour was dominant in Scotland until the independence debate in 2014 and in 2015 the SNP picked

percentage of votes and number of seats, and the two main parties obtain the most funding - Two main parties still control policy agenda and dominate the media = key policy ideas still generated by the main parties as being gov and official opposition they get most space and time - Key elections take place in Westminster, so whilst minor parties can have external influence, not in HOC to vote – 2019 the two major parties won 87% of seat	up 56 of 59 seats - 2010 did not deliver a majority gov – coalition - Reform is a large minority party who won 14% of the vote share - Events are making single issue parties more popular e.g Brexit in 2016 has led to the rise of Reform, single issue on immigration and Green with current climate crisis - DUP supported Tories in 2017 when TM lost her overall majority - Outside HOC, two party system is fragmented – e.g Reform and Greens get much more media time than the two main parties due to the gains they are making at such a startling rate. Polanski and Farage are both charismatic leaders compared to Stamer and Badenoch
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CONSERVATIVE POLICIES

Policy area	Right tendency	Centre-right tendency
Economic management	Support for free trade and deregulation of business; lowering of taxation on all with trade agreements negotiated on bilateral basis	The economy should be managed to ensure society does not become divided, nor the markets volatile, with support for furlough and lower rates of taxation for the poorest E.g further reducing employee national insurance to 6% by 2027 and making the 425,000 stamp duty threshold for first time buyers permanent
Social justice	Support for traditional, Christian-centred society based on individual value, and clear hierarchies and social structures E.g Focus on banning mobile phones in schools and tightening oversight of sex education	Ensuring the provision of a safety net, e.g during the COVID 19 crisis, a desire to 'level up' society, the idea of social mobility Support for more progressive ideas, such as same-sex marriage

Industry	Extensive privatisation of all areas Decrease union protections Limited government intervention	Government investment in infrastructure, like HS2 and new airports to facilitate private industry Financial support for struggling businesses to prevent economic hardship Acceptance of some necessary state services that can work with the private sector
Welfare	Seeks to reduce, if not end, welfare provisions, including proposals to privatise parts of the NHS More stringent tests of welfare recipients	Support for the NHS as part of the national identity The need for welfare provision, but with a purpose to encourage people into work for social stability E.g Launching new 'help to buy' scheme to foster an 'ownership society'
Law and Order	Support for strong law and order to ensure that society operates in a traditional, well-ordered way E.g increased prison sentences and increased police recruitment	Support for law and order, but also for individual freedoms and liberties Law and order should not be imposed in a draconian way
Foreign policy	Focus in British nationalism, and opposed to membership of supranational organisations like the EU Support for a strong and independent military capacity E.g Mandatory national service for 18 year olds or weekend civic service	Favours international cooperation to facilitate free trade and to intervene in foreign disputes that may not directly impact UK interests, such as international aid and peacekeeping services as part of supranational organisations
Environment	Opposition to environmental policies that may hinder business At the extreme end, may be climate deniers	Support for environmental initiatives and a focus on reducing the UK's carbon footprint E.g backing new small nuclear power stations and accelerating renewable energy projects
Constitutional reform	Opposition to progressive reforms Support for traditional systems and laws, including the monarchy, the HOL and the abolition of the HRA	Seeks to 'fix' problems left over from previous reforms, rather than removing those reforms

CONSERVATIVE FACTIONS

Faction	Core ideas	Key members
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Cornerstone	Traditional values: Christian, nationalist, and focused on family values Reactionary, opposed to social reforms such as same-sex marriage and legal abortion	Edward Leigh Jacob Rees-Mogg
Conservative way forward	Thatcherite, neoliberal Regulation of free markets through low taxation and deregulation Opposed to trade union power and welfare provision	Gerald Howarth (former defence minister) Christopher Chope
Tory Reform Group	One-nation conservatives, seeking national unity and believing that too much economic inequality is divisive	Ken Clarke (now in the Lords)
European Research Group (ERG)	Euroscepticism and the removal of the UK from EU membership	Past membership includes Suella Braverman, Jacob Rees-Mogg, Michael Gove

LABOUR POLICY:

Policy area	Left tendency	Centre-left tendency
Economic management	Expansionist: high public expenditure should be used to promote investment, improve public services and create jobs E.g removing inheritance tax loophole for farmers	A pragmatic view including targets to reduce public-sector debt
Social justice	Radical tax reforms to promote significant redistribution of income from rich to poor	Some adjustments to taxation to promote mild redistribution of income from high to low income groups
Industry	Large infrastructure industries to be brought into public ownership Strong regulation of private-sector industries and finance E.g imposing VAT on private schools E.g nationalising rail companies	Industry to remain in private hands and be regulated by the state

Welfare	Strong support for the NHS and state education Abolition of uni tuition fees More generous welfare benefits to help redistribute real income E.g bans on exploitative zero-hours contracts and new restrictions on 'fire and rehire' practices E.g removes the lower earnings limit and waiting period for statutory sick pay	Supports a strong welfare state and well-funded health service and education However, welfare benefits to be capped to ensure work pays and prevent abuse of the system E.g decision to keep Tory two child benefit cap
Law and order	Emphasis on social remedies to crime	A mixture of authoritarian measures and 'social' remedies to crime
Foreign policy	Largely 'isolationist', favouring non-intervention in world conflicts	Strong support for NATO and the alliance with the USA E.g unwavering commitment to UK's nuclear deterrent
Environment	Strong support for environmental protection and emissions control	Strong support for environmental protection and emissions control
Constitutional reform	More radical reforms, possibly including abolition of the lords, and more independence for local governments	Some reforms are supported, including an elected second chamber and a proportional electoral system

LABOUR FACTIONS

Faction	Core ideas	Key members
Momentum	Far left wing, seeking wealth redistribution through taxation, public ownership of key industries and the abandonment of the nuclear deterrent	John McDonnell Rebecca Long-Bailey
Blairites/ Social democrats	Centrist, key supporters of New Labour and Third Way	Yvette Cooper
Blue Labour	Focused on working-class issues and employment Socially Conservative, believing in traditional 'British values', anti-large scale immigration, pro-free markets, but with protection for UK industry from foreign competition	Maurice Glasman Shabana Mahmood

LIBERAL DEMOCRAT FACTIONS

Faction	Core ideas	Key members
Orange Book liberals	Traditional liberal values of free markets and the withdrawal of the state from excessive interference Focus on individual liberties	Ed Davey
Social liberals	Policies concerning social justice, with wealth distribution from rich to poor through taxation and welfare provision	Tim Farron Jo Swanson

Has the Labour Party left behind its traditional values?

Area	YES	NO
Economy	Minimum wage increase to 8 pounds and freezing income tax brackets may appear old Labour however this creates fiscal drag which mean people end up moving up the income tax brackets and paying more anyways Currently Labour pirates around the belief in a mixed economy with some Keynesian demand management, sees the benefit of the market for competition and generating growth e.g Blair's gov introduced academia programmes which converted state schools into institutions funded by charitable trusts and sponsors TB tried to privatise the Royal Mail but failed	Mansion tax (properties worth more than 2m will have a tax of 2.5k per year) aligns with old labour values of redistributive taxation Labour May 2025 nationalised Southwestern, C2C and Greater Anglia railway – aligns with old labour value of 'Common ownership of the means of production, distribution and exchange' Clause IV Labour constitution Opposed against TB trying to privatise Royal Mail
Welfare	PIP scandal – Kier government proposed tightening the eligibility criteria for PIP to save billions of pounds in April 2025. Goes against old Labour values of welfare state with safety net Winter Fuel Payments – July 2024 Labour announced to cut winter fuel payments, restricting to households with pensioners receiving pension credit – wanted to save 1.5	Scrapped the two child benefit cap in the 2025 budget – which aligns with old Labour beliefs in a safety net and benefits for the most needy Threat of rebellion against Kier of 100 Labour MPs so the gov backed down and made a U-turn in July 2025 WFP decision widely criticised and due to wide-scale uproar they reversed this decision in may 2025,

	billion. Cut would reduce the amount of families eligible from 11.4 to 1.5 million	52MPs did not participate in the vote
Law and Order	Jury trials scrapped for defendants who would be jailed for up to 5 years – new labour idea of pragmatism and efficiency over fairness, goes against idea of fair trial for all Senior Lawyers have said ‘David Lamy is proposing to massively restrict this ancient right’ that went back to the Magna Carta. Trying to fix Court backlog Prescribing Palestine action as terrorist organisation – surveillance, tough on crime, new Labour by Yvette Cooper – goes against traditional values of right to protest	Serious Violence duty act 2022, forces policing agencies to work together preserving the concept of crime as having root causes – aligns with old labour of rehabilitation Sentencing and early release – prisoners being released early under Labour’s justice plan

Conservative Party’s greatest weakness is its leaders

Year	YES	NO
2017	During a visit to the scene of the fire, May was booed by locals and heckled with chants of ‘resign’ Following the Chequers agreement announced in July 2018 and the subsequent resignations of David Davis and Boris Johnson, a plurality of the public by September believed May was no more incompetent than competent	‘Strong and Stable’ Theresa May initially seen as a strong and reliable leader, especially in comparison to Corbyn Grenfell tower fire – a week after the public went to the polls. YouGov found that 64% of respondents don’t think the gov responded well 2018 Windrush Scandal of dozens of Windrush immigrants being detained and erroneously threatened with deportation – 64% thought the gov handled the situation poorly but only 22% thought May herself was responsible
2019	PartyGate – parties in Downing Street in 2020 and 2021 when public health restrictions banned gatherings due to Covid, irresponsible Johnson illegally prorogued parliament in September 2019 to avoid scrutiny on the Brexit legislation he was trying to force through at the time 2021 independent investigation found that Priti Patel,	Covid was responsible April 2020, 66% of respondents in YouGov poll thought BOJO was good PM 200,000 died in the UK Lockdown from April to June 2020 caused fall in UK GDP by 20% Closure of many small businesses

	home sec, was treating her Civil service team so badly that her behaviour amounted to bullying – he ignored IMR	Mixed messages – ‘eat out to help out’ ‘stay home, save lives, and help the NHS’
2024	Rwanda, seen by SC as violation of human rights, immigration policy under Sunak 75 Tory MPs quit in the run-up to the election Rishi Sunak dubbed ‘bad PM’ by 68% in a poll by Sky News	3/5 believed the gov had handled the economy badly More than 80% of the public was dissatisfied with the gov’s OVERALL performance Paula Surridge: “First and foremost a verdict on the performance of the conservative government”

Lib Dem’s influential?

Area	Yes	No
Coalition	Succeeded in scrapping the national ID card, one of their key promises Universal infant free school meals Instrumental in passing legislation to legalise same sex marriage	Promise to scrap uni fees – one of their most important manifesto promises in the run up to the election, one of the key reasons why they won, gave it up in the coalition showing and allowed the cap of annual tuition fees to nearly triple, showing weakness in their authority compared to the tories – thousands of people took to the street, widespread anger 2015 General election saw the party reduced from 57 MPs to just 8 – loss of 80% of their parliamentary representation
Pushing policy	Windfall tax on energy companies, something Ed Davey has pointed out - led to labour 2024 stealing this policy and including a commitment to ‘proper windfall tax’ in their manifesto to help fund its green prosperity plan and establish great British energy Wera Hobhouse – Worker Protection Act, provides employees with protection against sexual harassment in the workplace Carer’s Leave Act – Wendy Chamberlain’s act gives	Conversions therapy prohibition bill November 2023: aimed to ban conversion practices for sexual orientation, the bills progression not guaranteed, Tory gov did not include the ban in its own legislative agenda – still hasn’t become law Abolition of the water services regulation authority bill: MP Tim Farron bill to abolish the OFWAT and replace it with a new clean water authority to improve regulation of water companies – never passed through parliament

	2.4 million unpaid carers the statutory right to 5 days unpaid leave per year	
Stragglers	2024: A string of by-election successes, gained 64 seats, ousted 4 Tory cabinet ministers like Gillian Keegan, former education secretary Broke the 'blue wall' – denied Tory success in constituencies once held by Cameron, May and Johnson In response to FPTP system – Party has rebuilt its councillor base, increasing its influence at the local level and strengthening its ability to campaign on local issues	Small number of seats in parliament means they aren't a significant opposition force First time in British history, 3rd parties are seeing significant success, such as Reform UK and Greens Lib Dem's membership has halved in the past 5 years compared to Green membership (increased by 80% since September 2025) As of September 2025, just 17% believe the Lib Dem's would run the country well

ELECTORAL SYSTEMS

Strengths of FPTP	Weaknesses of FPTP
- Easy to understand – one vote, one candidate - Provides 'strong and stable, stable and strong' (Theresa May) as they can pass laws easier e.g Since 1945 there has only been one coalition - Winners bonus where the party with the most votes gets a larger number of seats than proportional, allowing them to have a clear majority – Stamer won landslide victory, 174 seat majority despite 33.7% of the popular vote - Large majority governments can deliver on their manifesto commitments with minimal resistance, without relying on coalition partners – TB government with 179 seat majority, suffered only 4 defeats in total in the commons - Strong constituency link with MPs directly accountable to	- Winners bonus undermines the democratic legitimacy of government by producing highly disproportionate votes: Labour 2005 formed majority government, 63% of seats with just 33% of the vote - FPTP prioritises effective governance over fair representation - Doesn't always guarantee stable governments, May government relied on the support from the DUP without a majority and suffered numerous defeats in the commons, especially over Brexit - Simple plurality system means candidates can win seats without receiving a majority vote in their constituency – Labour's Terry Jeremy from South West Norfolk elected with just 26.7% of the vote - 2024 according to MakeVotesMatter, roughly 4/10 voters

their constituents – each constituency elects single MP who represents specific geographical area

- MPs tend to place considerable emphasis on constituency work such as holding local surgeries, answering emails and addressing local issues. Research shows MPs spend around 48% of their time on constituency work
- Attempts to reform the system have lacked popular support – 2011 AV referendum 68% voters rejected replacing FPTP with AV, suggesting that the public is satisfied with the current system
- In 2024, the first constituency result (Sunderland South) was announced at 23:15 on the day of the election, the result was clear the next morning and Stamer arrived at Downing Street as the new PM at 12:40pm the day after the election
- 1980s FPTP allowed Thatcher to bring about widespread changes to the economy whilst in 1997 it gave Blair's government the mandate to carry out extensive constitutional reforms
- Strong constituency link: December 2023 Conservative MPs supported Labour amendment aimed at speeding up compensation for victims of infected blood scandal, rebelling against 3 line conservative whip – influenced by local movements – Tory MP Caroline Nokes rebelled to represent local movement in Romsey and Southampton North constituency

said they were considering voting tactically, where voters support a candidate not because they prefer them but in order to prevent another party from winning, limits voters ability to fully express their political preferences

- Marginalises smaller and emerging parties which is increasingly problematic given the more plural political landscape that has developed – FPTP rewards parties with geographically concentrated support, meaning smaller parties with widespread but thinly distributed support struggle to gain parliamentary representation - 2024 Reform UK 14% but 5 seats (According to Make Votes Matter who modelled how the 2024 election would've differed under different electoral systems, Reform would've received 71 seats under STV and 91 under AMS)
- Parties with concentrated regional support, such as SNP, have historically been able to win a great number of seats despite smaller share of national vote
- FPTP contributes to political disengagement through the creation of 'safe seats' where the same party constantly wins by large margins. Elections under FPTP thus decided by few thousand swing voters in a small number of marginal constituencies
E.g if just 533 people had voted differently in 2017, it would have resulted in a majority gov instead of hung parliament
- Manchester Rusholme safe seat won by Labour in 2024 with 51.9% of the vote on 40% turnout
- Leads to perception of 'wasted votes' – 2024 only 1 in 4 voters had a vote that made a difference, directly affects turnout, 2024 60% (second lowest since universal suffrage in 1928)

AMS – Scotland, Wales

Strengths of AMS	Weaknesses of AMS
- More proportional and so have stronger mandate: 2016 SNP won 49% of seats and 42% of popular vote – if FPTP they would have won 82% of seats - Each voter has two votes – one for constituency candidates and one for the party - More voter choice and potentially greater representation with 2 representatives per constituent - FPTP Marginalises smaller and emerging parties which is increasingly problematic given the more plural political landscape that has developed – FPTP rewards parties with geographically concentrated support, meaning smaller parties with widespread but thinly distributed support struggle to gain parliamentary representation - 2024 Reform UK 14% but 5 seats (According to Make Votes Matter who modelled how the 2024 election would've differed under different electoral systems, Reform would've received 71 seats under STV and 91 under AMS) - AMS more proportional as the second 'top up' vote for a party acts as a corrective to the first constituency vote – 1999 Scottish Parliament election, Tory party won 0 constituency seats despite getting 15% of the vote but won additional 18 member seats in order to correct this (received 14% of seats overall)	- Complicated and less direct relationship between constituent and MP – AMS has two representatives, one for a constituency and another for larger areas. Confusing and creates different levels of representation that can weaken accountability - AMS prone to causing minority/ coalition governments who have many issues: Breakdown of Scottish gov in April 2024 – First Minister Humza Youssaf decided to end the coalition agreements after the Greens strongly criticised the SNP for abandoning a key climate change target – as a result the greens supported a no confidence motion against Youssaf who soon resigned

STV – Northern Ireland

Strengths of STV	Weaknesses of STV
- FPTP marginalises smaller and emerging parties which is increasingly problematic given the more plural political landscape that has developed – FPTP rewards parties with geographically concentrated support, meaning smaller parties with widespread but thinly distributed support struggle to gain parliamentary representation - 2024 Reform UK 14% but 5 seats (According to Make Votes Matter who modelled how the 2024 election would've differed under different electoral systems, Reform would've received 71 seats under STV and 91 under AMS) - STV almost always leads to coalition government, benefit in NI as it brings DUP and Sinn Fein together into cooperation	- Complicated and less direct relationship between constituent and MP – STV has numerous representatives for one constituency. Confusing and creates different levels of representation that can weaken accountability. - 2019 local elections in NI, in district electoral areas where there were 2 candidates running from the same party, the candidate whose surname was first alphabetically was elected 85% of the time – donkey voting - STV can lead to governments prone to conflict and indecision: NI assembly was suspended for 2 years following 2022 election as DUP refused to go into coalition with Sinn Fein in protest against the Northern Ireland Protocol – meant there was no executive and business in NI was run by Westminster until the gov was restored again in Feb 2024 - STV leads to coalitions in Scottish local elections, where after the 2022 elections, 94% of councils had no overall control - 2022 NI assembly elections saw 11,000 spoilt ballots which represented 1.3% of all votes cast

Criteria for evaluating electoral systems: Voter choice, proportionality, governance, representation

Referendums

FOR	AGAINST
- Can settle longstanding disputes and issues of interest: AV referendum was rejected 68% by voters - Make govs more responsive by forcing them to listen to	- Undermine the authority of parliament as it may be sidelined if they are overused. Takes away parliamentary sovereignty

public opinion between elections – i.e provide a check on government power, 2016 Brexit

- Promote participation and give everyone a voice every casted vote is the same worth, 2014 referendum for Scottish Independence had record 84.6% turnout. Direct democracy – public can speak for themselves rather than through an MP
- Referendums help to create a more informed electorate – make the public more active between elections which could increase overall turnout – 2017, 69%, highest since 1997

Youth mobilisation, turnout among 18-24 year olds rose by 16 percentage points from 2015

2015 general election record turnout in Scotland (66.7%) following 2014 referendum

- Media campaigns can expose voters to more information to increase their knowledge
- Allows single issue to be isolated and unambiguous popular verdict to be given. Especially important when trust in politicians is low and when an issue cuts across party lines – Brexit, public disagreed with parliament (75% of MPs supported remain) and Tories split on the issue
- Well regulated by the Electoral Commission – 2016 the government originally proposed to ask “should the UK remain a member of the EU?” But the commission considered it to be insufficiently neutral and insisted the ballot paper should present the two options: “Should the UK remain a member of the EU or leave the EU?”

- Too regular use of referendums might result in voter apathy or fatigue – low turnout can reduce the legitimacy of referendums e.g AV referendum had 42% turnout
- Referendums can be called twice to get the right answer – e.g 2014 independence referendum in Scotland they asked for another in 2018
- Campaigns can be misleading – both remain and leave campaigns in the 2016 referendum made claims that fact checkers have since disproven – e.g Leave NHS bus advert claim that ‘we send 350m a week to the EU’ and Cameron suggestion that if the UK left the EU house prices would plummet, there would be medicine shortages and millions would lose their job
- Real meaning of voting yes and no in both 2016 and 2014 referendum was far from clear – did it mean staying in the single market, customs union or leaving without a deal?
- gov can choose when to call them and use public resources to back their preferred outcome. Gov can control the questions and options on the ballot paper e.g 2014 choice was yes or no even though many voters wanted a third option for ‘greater devolution’
- 2016 the Leave campaign argued that the remain campaign had an unfair advantage because the government and civil service supported it
- 2016 the Electoral Commission reported that the arguments used by the leaders of both campaigns included a large degree of distortion, and that there should have been a greater regulation of referendum campaigns to ensure people received a fair representation of the arguments – e.g the negative impact of EU immigration to the UK was overstated by the Leave campaign

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| | <ul style="list-style-type: none">- 1997 Welsh Devolution referendum had 50.3% yes on 50% turnout, failed to engage voters leading to illegitimate outcome |
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AV Referendum 2011: 5th May

- Turnout v low (42%) and 68% voted no
- Nick Clegg wanted to reform FPTP to help the Lib Dem's
- Tories campaigned 'say no to AV'
- AV requires reasonable degree of numeracy and literacy

Scottish Independence Referendum 2014:

- Called following the growth in popularity of the SNP in the past decade which indicated significant support for independence among the Scottish population
- 84.5% turnout, 55% voted against independence
- Post-Brexit Scotland proposed another referendum in 2018 because they had overwhelmingly voted to stay (62% to 38%) but May refused
- Choice was yes or no even though many voters wanted a third option for 'greater devolution'

Brexit Referendum 2016

- Held because Cameron promised in Tory 2015 Manifesto
- Growing Euroscepticism and Tories faced threat from UKIP – 2014 European Parliament elections where UKIP won 26.6% of the vote and was the largest party
- Cameron wanted the debate to be over and thought that leaving it to the people was the only way to do so
- Most MPs wanted to stay
- High turnout of 72.2% - 52% voted to leave and 48% to remain
- Leave = Michael Gove, BOJO, the SUN, the Daily Telegraph, Daily Mail

- Ken Clarke was the only Conservative MP who voted against Cameron's referendum legislation and argued that issue of EU membership was far too complex to expect citizens to reach a balanced judgement. Knew it would lead to huge misinformation campaigns
- No plan on how to actually 'get Brexit done' and thus only formally left in 2020

VOTING BEHAVIOUR AND THE MEDIA

Classification	Description	Typical occupation
A and B	Higher and intermediate managerial, administrative, professional occupations	Banker Doctor Company Director Senior executive
C1	Supervisory, clerical and junior managerial, administrative, professional occupations	Teacher Office manager IT manager Social worker
C2	Skilled manual occupations	Plumber Hairdresser Mechanic Train Driver
D and E	Semi-skilled and unskilled manual occupations, unemployed	Labourer Bar staff Call centre staff Unemployed

1979- Thatcher, 1997- Blair, 2015- Cameron, 2019- Johnson, 2024 – Stamer

1979 GENERAL ELECTION

Labour government, which had come to power with a small majority in 1974 had suffered the loss of a number of MPs and repeated crises. By 1979, public opinion had turned against labour, allowing the conservatives, under Margaret Thatcher, to make large gains and win a clear majority

Conservatives were to be in power for the next 18 years

- Conservatives: 63 more seats than previous election, 43.9% of the vote, 43 seat majority
- Labour: 50 fewer seats than previous election, 36.9% of the vote

Demographic:

- Sharp decline in number of people describing themselves as 'working class' at the time of this election. May have eroded Labour's vote.
- Conversely, the middle class was growing, helping the conservatives

Key issue: power of trade unions and economy

- 'Winter of Discontent': Winter of 1978-1979 there had been a wave of strikes by public-sector workers, leading to bins being left unemptied, shortages of power and disruption of public transport
- Which party was best placed to control union power?
- UK economy saw high inflation, growing unemployment and falling growth. Conservative response was to plan a return to free markets and to curb union power
- They argued that prices would come down if unemployment continued to rise so that wages would fall

Party leaders

- James Callaghan, Labour PM before the election, ironically had a more favourable image than Thatcher
- Seen as reliable and likeable where Thatcher was seen as distant and too 'posh'
- Thatcher had also been unpopular as education secretary in the early 1970s
- Some members of the electorate may have been reluctant to vote for a female PM
- Conservatives thus won in spite of rather than because of their leader

Turnout

- Turnout was a little down on past trends, largely due to abstentions by the working class and union members, who were labour's core voters
- Opinion polls may have played a role in boosting Conservative turnout as they showed an increasingly close race

Campaign

- 1979 election was the first campaign where the parties focused on using the media, rather than having the media passively report on what had happened without sharing opinions
- Press conferences were timed to provide stories for the midday news, afternoon walkabouts by leaders were designed to coincide with the early evening news, and major speeches were timed to make the late evening news
- As a result of opinion polls, which showed that the public did not like adversarial campaigns, the two main parties avoided making attacks on each other, especially after criticism was levelled at the conservatives following an insult-laden first 'attack and'
- While Callaghan certainly 'won' the campaign, coming across as the more popular leader and closing the polling gap between labour and the conservatives, it was not enough to win the election

Gender	Men were evenly split between the two main parties Women showed slight preference for the conservatives
Age	Labour won among the 18-24 age group, but Conservatives won across all other age groups Labour support declined most in the 35-45 age group
Class	The conservatives remained dominant with the A,B, and C1 voters. Labour won the C2, D and E vote, but the conservatives gained swings of 11% and 9% respectively across these groups
Region	All areas swung towards the conservatives, but the swing was much more pronounced in southern England

1997 GENERAL ELECTION

In 1992, the conservatives had won a fourth election in a row with a majority of 23 seats. Since then. Their reputation as a party of government had suffered and the Labour Party had reformed as 'New Labour' under Tony Blair. The 1997 election resulted in the Tory Party's worst electoral defeat since 1906 and Labour's largest ever electoral victory

Massive defeat for conservatives which took them over 10 years to recover, Labour stayed in power for next 13 years

- Labour: 145 more seats than previous election, 43.2% of vote, **179 seat majority**
- Conservative: 165 fewer seats than previous election, 30.7% of the vote,

Demographic:

- Blair and Labour leadership recognised that the traditional working class, Labour's natural core vote, was diminishing in size and the party couldn't rely on it to get into power
- Therefore decided to 'woo' the middle classes, part of the conservatives' core vote, by adopting centrist policies
- Young were also persuaded to vote Labour as it represented a break from traditional, out-of-date politics

Valence:

- Image of Tory party, which had been in power for 18 years, was tired, and the party was divided over Europe
- Tories had also presided over a deep economic recession in the early 1990s – competence
- Labour had no economic record to defend and appeared to be a younger, fresher party, united around a definable set of policies – the 'third way'
- The main problem for Tories was that the electorate remembered the recession of the late 80s and early 90s and blamed the party for it. General sense that the conservatives mismanaged the economy

Party leaders

- Conservative Prime Minister John Major appeared grey, unexciting and weak whereas Tony Blair was clearly in command, young and attractive, with a clear vision
- Liberal Democrat leader, Paddy Ashdown, had a positive image which led to 30 seat increase for Lib Dem's from previous election

Turnout

- Figure of 71% seems healthy by modern standards but was much lower than typical levels in the past
- Beginning of long-term decline in turnout, a watershed in political participation

Political issues: NHS/ Education and party image

- Both services had been in decline, Labour promised to make huge investments in both in order to raise standards
- Chancellor Gordon Brown promised to be financially responsible, which was a strong message, especially as Labour had a bad reputation as a 'tax and spend' party
- Labour was fortunate that economic recovery was under way when it took office, so it could pay for the improvements in public services
- In the years 1992-94 John Major had presided over Conservative Party divided over the Maastricht treaty, which transferred huge amounts of power to the EU, hangover from this still present in 1997, as was the party's reputation for 'sleaze'

Campaign

- Election campaign lasted 6 weeks, far longer than 31 day average previously
- Major hoped this would expose Labour divisions and put pressure on Blair
- Both campaigns focused on the leaders, touring marginal seats and using campaign buses and planes
- Labour's campaign was strict and well organised, run from the Millbank Media Centre
- Use of media soundbites, like Blair's three priorities being 'education, education, education' helped galvanise the public
- Conservatives focused on fears of Labour restoring union power and Blair being untrustworthy
- Conservative Party had to spend much of its time dealing with the issue of sleaze and financial corruption, which distracted from its wider campaign
- Conservatives tried to focus on negative anti-Labour campaign while Labour focused on positive 'pro-Blair' campaign
- Elections saw enormous step towards disciplined, media-focused electioneering modelled on US politics

Policies

- Conservatives tried to focus policies on economic recovery, but the issue of Europe dominated and divided the party, especially with the presence of the Referendum Party
- Labour focused on five specific pledges: cut class sizes in schools, introduce fast track punishment for young offenders, cut NHS waiting lists, get 250,000 unemployed under 15s into work, cut VAT and not raise income tax

Opinion polls

- Having been spectacularly wrong in 1992, the polls made a more concerted effort to survey a wider cross-section of society
- Much more accurate in 1997, but the legacy of distrust from 1992 meant that New Labour did not believe them and kept campaigning as if they might lose
- By showing Labour as clear favourite, turnout might have been suppressed slightly

Gender	Labour closed the gender gap, with men and women equally likely to support Labour
Age	The conservatives remained dominant with over 65s, but Labour won decisively among all other age groups
Ethnicity	Labour beat the conservatives among white voters (43%) and BAME voters (70%). The conservatives gained only 32% of the white vote and mere 18% of BAME vote.
Class	Labour gained across all groups, most notably with C1 (+19%) and C2 (+15%), although conservatives still 'won' the A and B vote and the C1 group was tied
Region	Labour gained votes across all regions, bucking the trend towards a Conservative South and a Northern Labour. Conservatives wiped out in Scotland and Wales and reduced to only 11MPs in London, becoming a party of the English suburbs and shires

2015 GENERAL ELECTION

2010 UK saw the creation of its first coalition government since WW2. Lib Dem's paid the price and were almost wiped out as a parliamentary party, losing seats across England, mostly to the Conservative Party. The SNP broke Labour's traditional dominance of Scotland and replaced the Lib Dem's as the third party in Westminster. Conservatives won their first majority since 1992.

Shock of defeat completely destabilised Labour Party

Huge left-wing backlash over failed policies of the leadership, leading to the party electing extreme left-winger Jeremy Corbyn in place of Ed Milliband

- Conservatives: 28 more seats than 2010, 36.9% of the vote, 12 seat majority
- Labour: 24 fewer seats than 2010, 30.4% of vote
- SNP: 50 more seats than 2010, 56 seats
- Lib Dem: 48 fewer seats than 2010, 8 seats

Demographic:

- Large proportion of Labour's core working-class vote was captured by UKIP, especially in depressed areas of the country
- Lib Dem's lost all 15 of their seats in southwest England. Dispelled the idea that they had a core vote in that region
- Conservatives dominated south of England as a whole
- SNP nearly swept the board in Scotland, Labour's regional heartland taken away

Valence

- All parties suffered from negative image other than SNP
- Conservatives still divided over Europe and immigration
- Lib Dem's blamed for many of the shortcomings of the previous coalition government
- Labour not trusted with the economy and its competence was constantly called into question
- Media may have had an impact of warning about the dangers of a likely Labour-SNP coalition, as indicated by opinion polls – some voters turned away from this prospect by voting for conservatives
- UKIP took more votes from Labour than conservatives
- Conservatives benefitted from collapse of Lib Dem voting.

Party leaders

- All leaders other than SNP Nicola Sturgeon suffered a negative image
- David Cameron's image was the least negative

- Nick Clegg of Lib Dem and Ed Milliband of Labour were both short of public respect

Political issues: economic management

- Conservatives still more trusted with the economy than Labour
- Election was dominated by the prospect of a referendum on UK membership of the EU
- Conservatives and UKIP were rewarded for their support of such a referendum
- Scottish referendum of 2014 was a key event, put the SNP in a powerful position in Scotland

Campaigns

- Second campaign in which televised debates featured
- Cameron refused to debate with Milliband head-to-head, agreeing only to a seven-person leadership debate, which proved bland and made it difficult for Milliband to stand out
- Although Labour focused on the NHS and many celebrity endorsements, Conservatives focused on working families and questioned 'Labour's magic money tree' which was more effective
- Both sides stressed the dangers of possible coalition, either SNP-Labour or Conservative-UKIP
- Conservatives focused heavily on campaigning against the Lib Dem's in England as a means of preventing Labour-SNP coalition
- SNP targeted both Labour and Lib Dems for failing to consider Scottish issues

Policies

- Labour focused on five key pledges: To balance the books and cut the deficit, to freeze energy bills until 2017, to recruit 20,000 more nurses and 8000 more GPs, to prevent immigrants claiming benefits for 2 years, to reduce university tuition fees to 6000 per year
- Conservatives pledged to make welfare cuts, but refused to say where these cuts would be until after the election. Promised in/out EU referendum, tax-free income for those on minimum wage, up to 20 hours per week of free childcare

Opinion polls

- Increasingly reliant on digital methods, got it wrong by underestimating the number of older voters who would turnout and be more likely to vote Tory
- Labour thus chose to fight a campaign on Labour policies rather than anti-conservative

- Labour-SNP threats may have influenced tactical voting and boosted Conservative turnout

Gender	Conservatives won similar share of the vote among men and women (37% and 38%) Labour had clear gender gap with more women than men
Age	Age divide continued Labour won with 18-24 age group and tied with conservatives among 40-49 Conservatives won with all other groups, achieving 20% advantage over labour with over-65s
Ethnicity	Labour won 67% of the Black Caribbean vote compared with Tory 21% Conservatives decisively won with people of Asian origins
Class	A,B,C1 and C2 categories all voted Conservative Labour did win with D and E classes Conservative votes among A,B,C1 increased from 2010
Region	England, outside major cities and industrial centres, overwhelmingly voted conservative, at the expense of the Lib Dem's Labour and Lib Dem's nearly wiped out in Scotland by SNP who won 56/59 seats

2019 GENERAL ELECTION

Following the close election and minority government of 2017, both main parties had seen divisions grow. It was not clear how the 2019 election would play out, but Labour's vote collapsed across the UK, allowing the conservative's to win their largest majority since the 1987 election. In Scotland, the SNP made significant gains, having fallen back in 2017.

- Conservatives, 47 more seats, 43.6% of vote, 80 seat majority
- Labour, 59 fewer seats, 32.2% of vote

Conservatives were given a clear mandate and ensured continued dominance of the Conservative Party since 2010. First sizeable majority since the 2005 election and saw Jeremy Corbyn resign as Labour leader.

Demographic issues:

- Shift in working class support across northern industrial areas as former labour and UKIP voters - tired of the Brexit deadlock, voted for the conservatives over Labour, reducing the 'red wall' of northern support
- Labour continued to focus on younger and working-class voters with more socialist manifesto
- Conservatives focused on appealing to older and working class voters angry over the failure to deliver Brexit

Valence and Brexit

- Parliament had been in chaos since the previous election and the public had been frustrated by all sides' inability to move forward on Brexit
- Consequently, the clear message being offered by new PM Boris Johnson on Brexit became the main focus of the campaign, compared with the vague and complicated messages of the Labour Party
- The issue of antisemitism dominated the Labour Party in the run-up to the election, as did the formation of new parties, including Nigel Farage's Brexit Party and the creation of the Independent Group for Change
- The decision of the Brexit party not to contest seats won by the Conservatives in 2010 and seats with strong Conservative Brexit supporters meant the right predominantly only had one party to choose on the issue
- Liberal Democrat had seen their total number of MPs increase to 21 with defections from both Labour and the Conservatives, but this only seemed to alienate supporters who did not want to be associated with members of one of the main parties
- Issue of Scottish independence saw the SNP gain more seats

Party leaders

- Boris Johnson benefited from having been PM and leader for a limited time and stuck to a strategy of not appearing too often in the media, instead relying on his existing reputation and media profile from his time as London Mayor
- Unlike Theresa May in 2017, he appeared focused and more determined and clear in his policy-making than Jeremy Corbyn
- Nicola Sturgeon continued to enjoy a positive image in Scotland
- Liberal Democrat leader Jo Swanson alienated the public by appearing to lack sincerity and pledging to repeal Article 50

Turnout

- Turnout saw a slight drop in 2019 from the 69% of 2017, perhaps because this was a less close election than previously but also perhaps because a December election encouraged some voters

Campaign

- Campaign was more subdued than previous ones partly because it took place during the winter and partly because Johnson seemed to be absent for much of the campaign, appearing in public relatively rarely for a serving leader
- Although he did participate in a head-to-head debate with Corbyn, the main objective seemed to be to let the issue of Brexit persuade the voters
- The slogan 'Get Brexit Done', coined by Dominic Cummings, was particularly influential
- Corbyn managed a solid campaign with lots of public speeches but was unable to whip up the enthusiasm he had in 2017
- Social media attack ads were more prevalent in this campaign than in any other and the Electoral commission seemed unable to do much about it

Political issues/ rational choice

- The election cycle was dominated by the extension of the deadline for leaving the EU from October 2019 to January 2020 and the inability of parliament to find a solution for Brexit
- Former big names from both main parties urged members not to vote for their party, including Michael Heseltine and John Major on the Conservative side and Alistair Campbell for Labour
- During the Campaign, floods hit parts of England and Johnson was criticised for not declaring them an emergency
- Journalists from the Labour-supporting Mirror newspaper were banned from the Conservative campaign bus
- Shortly before the election, a NATO summit was held in Watford, allowing Johnson to appear with other world leaders, including President Donald Trump

Opinion polls

- Opinion polls were again under scrutiny with the memory of 2015
- The polls seemed to indicate a conservative win throughout, which perhaps shaped the campaign as one for the conservatives to lose rather than for Labour to win
- The polls underestimated the scale of conservative victory

Gender	Slight gender gap between Conservatives and Labour but mainly the result of large gap in the 18-24 group, with 64% of women in this group voting labour
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	Gender gap far less pronounced elsewhere, with only slight female bias towards Labour
Age	Age was once again the main dividing line in the British electorate, especially women, far more likely to vote Labour The older a person became, the more likely they were to vote Conservative, with 39 as the tipping point
Ethnicity	BAME voters continued to favour Labour over the conservatives, leading 64% to 20% Conservatives won the white vote over Labour 48% to 29%
Class	Conservatives won across all social classes and the percentage split between Labour and the Conservatives remained pretty consistent across all groups Conservatives won a higher proportion of votes among C2, D and E classes than they did with A, B and C1 groups
Region	The conservatives dominated rural and southern England (outside London) and made gains in industrial northern areas and in Wales SNP gained seats in Scotland to continue domination there, while the Conservatives lost 7 seats, but remained the second-biggest party Slight rise in nationalist parties in NI

2024 GENERAL ELECTION

After 14 years of conservative government, Labour achieved a decisive landslide victory under Kier Stamer.

- Labour: 211 more seats, 33.7%, 174 seat majority
- Conservatives: 244 fewer seats, 23.7% of the vote
- Lib Dem: 61 more seats

Demographic factors

- Collapse of Conservative support in southern England, including safe seats
- Labour regained much of the 'red wall'

- Lib Dem's targeted and won affluent southern seats
- Reform split the right-wing vote, attracting disaffected conservative voters

Valence

- Strong anti-incumbency after 14 years of Conservative rule
- Government failed to follow its own COVID restrictions, 'partygate scandal' late 2021, resulted in the resignation of Boris Johnson who had previously been an electoral asset
- Major drop in Conservative Party support in Liz Truss' 49 day premiership, as the unfounded tax cuts in her 2022 mini-budget caused the pound's value to plummet
- Multiple leadership changes damaged party image
- Labour seen as stable, moderate, competent – presented itself as the antithesis of the Tories, moved to the centre ground and promised not to raise income tax, national insurance or corporation tax, making the Tory usual attack line ineffective
- Reform UK capitalised on dissatisfaction, especially on immigration
- 2/3 public said the conservatives did not deserve to win re-election and over 3/5 believed that government had handled the economy poorly

Party leaders

- Rishi Sunak was one of the least popular party leaders fighting an election in history, with a net favourability of -51% with the public
- He was tarnished by his involvement with Partygate, left a D-Day event early to attend ITV interview, viewed as smug and out of touch
- Stamer won despite net favourability of -17% on election day according to YouGov
- Stamer emphasised his small town roots in his first campaign speech in 2024 and called himself a 'real politician', emphasised working class background to win Labour supporters approval and to position himself as the opposite of the Tories

Political issues/ Rational choice

- Cost-of-living crisis dominant
- NHS crisis

- 78% of voters thought the conservatives were handling immigration poorly

Policies

- In many areas, Labour and Conservatives policies were very similar – both promised to increase defence spending to 2.5%, both promised not to raise income tax, both promised to invest in NHS and tackle illegal immigration

Campaign

- Lib Dem's Ed Davey had unique idea of campaigning where he would do many stunts to encourage voters to 'take the leap' and vote for Lib Dem's for the 'first time'. Stunt like bungee jumping, paddle boarding, slip and slide.
- Labour focused on winning voters where it mattered and targeted swing seats the most.

Education	23% of people with only GCSE or lower voted Reform. Labour beat the Tories in higher and lower social grades. Homes of a 70,000+ income voted 40% Labour
Gender	Twice as many young women (18-24) voted green than men (23% to 12%). 17% of men voted reform compared to 12% of women
Age	Key division in age, young= labour, older = conservative. Only 8% voted conservative under 30, but 46% of 70 and older voted conservative. 18% of 18-24 voted Green.
Ethnicity	Amongst Pakistani and Bangladeshi Britons, 41% say the issue in Gaza is their top concern and many voted Green (29%). Black voters 72% labour.
Region	Labour regained Red-wall and won 37 of 28 Red Wall seats, including Blyth Valley who elected a Conservative MP for the first time in its 69 year history, Tories only have 21 of the 73 London constituencies

The Media

- Tabloid media tends to focus on big scandals e.g Partygate

- Media exposes corruption e.g 2008 MP expenses scandal, prince Andrew, and when scrutinised on question time
- 1995 The Sun backs Blair – can change the course of the election outcome
- Rupert Murdoch

Influence	Reinforcement	Shaping agenda
The sun endorses Brexit 2016 – headlines of ‘beLeave in Britain’ arguably influenced undecided voters Ed Miliband’s Bacon sandwich incident 2014 – media focus on always photo whilst eating sandwich which symbolised him being unfit for leadership leading up to 2015 election 2017 Tories spend £2million on Facebook advertising 1997 The Sun backs Blair influenced voters as the Sun is historically conservative	Tabloid criticism of Labour in 2019 – the Sun and the Daily Mail amplify criticism of Jeremy Corbyn’s leadership The Daily Mail Consistently supports conservative policies and leadership Brexit coverage in Right-leaning outlets with persistent negative portrayals of the EU, e.g in Telegraph – expressed and reinforced Eurosceptic beliefs amongst their core readership, maintaining pressure for a hard-Brexit stance	2017 campaign – Labour grassroots movement in campaign effectively used social media to shape young voters perception of the 2017 election with videos of JC being relatable BBC debates and leadership interviews – high profile televised debates and interviews BOJO v Corbyn 2019 where Johnson had an assured performance against Corbyn apparent idealism Cambridge analytics and microtargeting 2016 – the manipulation of voter data of microtarget ads during the Brexit referendum shaped voter understanding of key issues – e.d ads emphasised the NHS funding ‘dividend’ from leaving the EU

Type	Influence	Irrelevance
Print media	The sun 2017 had 30 million monthly reads Sun and Daily Mail were the two most read newspapers 58% of over 65 use print news	Print media readership decrease by 52% from 2010 to 2018 2016 the print of the Independent ceased and it became only online 2005-2017 saw 238 local newspapers shut down

		Only 4% of 18-24 year olds get their news from newspapers
Broadcast media	54% of 55+ use TV broadcasting for news Since 2017 BBC and all commercial stations are monitored by OFCOM In the 2000s – national and political culture was created as all families would watch the news at same time together	9% of 18-24 use this as their source of media
Social media	84% of 18-24 get their news from online sources, social media alone is 24% Celebrity politics focuses on leadership not the party 2013 social media rise, Twitter Facebook and TikTok 2019 – 73% of the public used facebook 2017 over 1.5 million people under 35 registered to vote one month before the election due to online campaigns encouraging them to vote	Issues of fake news as social media is unregulated. AI 2016 Brexit Campaign – remain camp argued that leave camp were misleading voters by spreading false info – especially about the NHS 2017 election – the Sun argued there were misleading claims made by Labour that the Tories wanted to privatise the NHS

Election	Media moment	How It may have influenced the outcome	How it may NOT have influenced the outcome
1979	The sun issued a headline saying ‘crisis? What crisis?’ As Jim Callaghan’s reaction to the ‘winter of discontent’	Callaghan never actually said this, but it caught the public imagination, suggesting that he was out of touch with public opinion, thereby swinging opinion against a formerly popular PM	Polls showed that Callaghan remained personally popular throughout the election and was actually far ahead of Thatcher. He was Labour’s biggest electoral asset
1997	The sun switched support from the Conservatives to Labour	The Sun (and most of the press) publicly switched support to Blair and New Labour, persuading many former conservative voters to vote Labour instead	Polls suggested Labour was on course for a large victory anyways The sun and the press were simply reacting to the existing situation
2010	The first televised debate was won by Nick Clegg	Clegg was reported as having won the first leaders’ debate, raising his profile at the expense of David Cameron, perhaps costing the Conservatives the votes needed for an	The Liberal Democrats only increased their share of the vote by 1 percent nationally and actually lost seats, suggesting any impact from the debate

		outright majority	was, at best, limited
2015	The televised leaders' debate	Ed Milliband fell off the stage and gave an overexcited 'Hell yes, I'm tough enough' response to a question, making him appear less Prime Ministerial than Cameron	Opinion polls suggested the debate made no real difference to voting intentions, merely confirming existing intentions
2019	Facebook advertising	At the start of December 2019, the Facebook ad library showed the Conservatives had 25000 live paid-for advertisements, while Labour only had 250. The conservatives went on to seal a huge victory over Labour.	At the same time, the Liberal Democrat's had 3000 paid ads on Facebook, more than the Conservative Party, yet they lost seats

Banning opinion polls?

For banning	Against banning
- Opinion polls may influence the way people vote - Opinion polls have proved to be inaccurate so they mislead the public - Arguably politicians should not be captive to changing public opinion as expressed in the polls	- It would infringe on the principle of freedom of expression - If publication of opinion polls is banned, they will become available privately for organisations that can afford to pay for them - Opinion polls give valuable information about people's attitudes that can usefully guide politicians - The polls would still be published abroad and people could access them through the internet

Do Polls have a positive impact on UK democracy?

Yes	No
- Parties and Govs use polling to help inform decision	- If voting intention polls help party leaders shape policy and make

making: 2017 Labour manifesto chimed with policy issue polls that showed the public backed the re-nationalisation of railways and building of thousands of new council homes

- 2019 Manifesto chimed with policy issue polls with its focus on 'Get Brexit Done' and increased spending pledges in the police, NHS and education
- Opinion polls can encourage political participation and inform public debate – if the media reports a close contest this is more likely to encourage voters
- Voting intention reported being close in 2010, 2015, 2017 and saw 69% turnout
- Opinion polls allow politicians to have access to public attitudes and check voting intentions and so stops the gov misrepresenting the public
- 2012 coalition gov was forced to reverse the 3p rise in tax on fuel in response to pressure from monitoring groups, industry leaders and backbench MPs
- 2017 TM was forced to reverse her policy to make elderly people pay for their social care and it was nicknamed the 'dementia tax' by Labour after her lead in voting intention polls halved in one day

decision if they are accurate, however they were inaccurate in 2015 and 2017 so the polls can misinform party leaders on public opinion

- When TM called a snap election in 2017 the average conservative lead in the polls was 17% but the final result gave the Tories only a 2.4% lead – this inaccuracy of polling led to the Tories losing their majority in the Commons
- Questions over if DC would have included a referendum about the EU in his 2015 manifesto if the polls hadn't predicted another hung parliament
- 2012 the Chancellor George Osborne U-turned on a number of measures in his budget including VAT on hot foods such as the 'pasty tax' due to public annoyance. This became known as the 'omnishambles' budget making the gov look incoherent
- If polling comes out that there is clearly huge support for one side there can be low voter turnout e.g. 2024 turnout was only 59% because polls predicted Labour landslide
- Political parties shouldn't just follow opinion polls, they should also shape their own agenda and policy. 2025 – Stamer called a pragmatic politician who seems to overly follow polls and do the things to maintain popularity, such as removing the two child benefit cap and creating a mansion tax for houses over 2 million (Nov 2025)
- Also seen in Labour U-turn on PIP and shrinking the winter fuel allowances

The impact on elections and referendums:

- Report of the inquiry into the 2015 British General election opinion polls commissioned by the British polling council and market research society stated that 'the expectation of a hung parliament in the final days and weeks of the campaign was so

	strong and widely held that the sense of shock and disbelief was palpable when the result of the exit poll was announced' - The polling inaccuracies led the Tories to lead with a campaign that played on the fears of Labour, taking power with the support of the SNP as a coalition government
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Individual voting theories

- Valence
- Rational choice
- Issue voting

Long-term social factors:

- Social class
- Age
- Region
- Ethnicity
- Gender
- Class dealignment
- Partisan dealignment

Short-term factors:

- Valence
- Economic voting
- Rational choice
- Issue voting

- Tactical voting
- Party leaders
- The press
- Broadcast media
- Social media
- Opinion polls